

**ALL PLAY:** MacCarthaigh (standing) explains SERVE to Rajasthan education officials



## To Serve and Protect

**An Irish educationist's study module could be the answer to distressing children during examinations**

■ By Elora Sen

Long before reports of suicide by students faring badly in examinations caught the nation's attention, an Irish priest and educationist, who has made India his home, started a mission to reduce the suffering of the young student inflicted by the country's education system. It was one such story that forced Brendan MacCarthaigh, 70, to come up with the Student's Empowerment, Rights and Vision through Education (SERVE) in 1996. Sahana Paul, 10, who had committed suicide, signed off with a note, "ps: Sorry for my bad spelling". "It killed me. This beautiful child had been carrying such a burden," MacCarthaigh says.

Since then he has been fighting to get his system incorporated in the country's mainstream education. "Children are never told that they are appreciated for what they are. They are always reminded that the family izzat depends on their report cards. Our education system is damaging the child," he says. Not surprisingly, the National Crime Records Bureau says that nearly 24 per cent of all suicides in India are committed by children who fail in examinations.

In the SERVE system, a class is divided into groups and the children teach each other, while the teacher acts as a guide. There are evaluation systems and the students are geared up



for the bigger board examinations too. But all this is done without the child being constantly told to memorise what the teachers say. The children ask questions and find answers themselves. This gives a boost to their self-confidence helping them to face board examinations later without the fear factor.

Working from his rather unassuming office in central Kolkata, MacCarthaigh carries on his mission with a team of volunteers and just one paid secretary. His efforts received a major boost when the then director of State Council Educational Research and Training (SCERT), Delhi, Janaki Rajan, allowed the system to be adopted in the state in 2001. Nearly nine lakh children benefited from it and several teachers were trained as well. However, SCERT stopped using it after the end of Rajan's term. Apart from Delhi, Rajasthan also supports this programme.

SERVE faced maximum resistance from West Bengal. "The Left Front Government does not want the system to take roots here as it will create a thinking mass which cannot be controlled," says MacCarthaigh. He, however, found support from the La Martiniere for Girls' where the system is used in the lower classes. The students are learning far better with less stress and fear of examinations. Hopefully, more and more schools will take lessons from MacCarthaigh's module. ■